

REACTION

HOW THE AGE OF 18 MIGHT REVIVE INDIA'S STUTTERING S AGAINST OTHER DISEASES

VACCINES RECOMMENDED FOR INCLUSION IN INDIA'S UIP

Several vaccines for adolescents and adults are recommended for inclusion in India's Universal Immunisation Programme (UIP), but not much traction has happened

- Measles rubella (MR) vaccine
- Tetanus and adult diphtheria (Td) vaccine
- Human papilloma virus (HPV) vaccine
- Mumps/MMR vaccine
- Hepatitis-A vaccine
- Typhoid vaccine
- Varicella/ chicken pox vaccine
- Hepatitis-B vaccine
- Meningococcal disease vaccine

SOURCE: BT RESEARCH

THE COVID-19 PANDEMIC has changed humankind in far-reaching ways—from the way we shop to the way we work to the way we unwind. Maybe even the way we approach disease prevention. For the adolescent population, if the response to India's mass immunisation programme is anything to go by, getting a jab has become part of their 'to do' list.

India has perhaps never rolled out as massive a vaccination programme for its adolescent population as it has during the Covid-19 pandemic. As of April 21, more than 25.3 million adolescents had received their first shot of the Covid-19 vaccine, according to data from the Union health ministry. This, perhaps, sets the stage for a dedicated inoculation programme for adolescents for vaccine-preventable diseases or VPDs; it is also a signal to the pharma industry to invest in this space, considering the high uptake of Covid-19 vaccines. But more on that later.

The vaccine story for adolescents in India has largely been unimpressive, though there were more than 250 million adolescents (those be-

tween the ages of 10 and 19) in the country in 2021, according to UNICEF. And while India's Universal Immunisation Programme (UIP) is one of the largest in the world in terms of the quantity of vaccines used and the number of beneficiaries, it is largely targeted at infants and children under five years of age. In fact, the pharma industry's vaccine segment that caters to the adolescent and adult population witnessed de-growth of about 17 per cent in the past one year, according to AWACS, a pharma market research company.

Data shows that GSK Pharma, a segment leader, recorded de-growth of 51 per cent for its pneumonia vaccine for the March 2021-February 2022 period. Likewise, Sanofi India's sales for its tetanus combination vaccines fell 25 per cent, and 44 per cent for its influenza vaccine, while Biological E. recorded a fall of 8 per cent for its tetanus vaccine. Then, Bharat Biotech witnessed over 44 per cent de-growth for its anti-rabies vaccine in the same period. Similarly, Zydus Cadila, which makes Covid-19 vaccines for adolescents, saw de-growth of 49 per cent for its influenza vaccine; and Indian Immunologicals had de-growth of 22 per cent for its anti-rabies vaccine, AWACS data shows.

India also witnessed the biggest drop in routine childhood immunisation coverage in recent times, according to data collated by the World Health Organization (WHO)

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